

DECODED EXPLAINED

8th August, 2026

A Climate Resilience Pathway Between India and China

A climate resilience pathway between India and China

This year, El Niño delayed the monsoon in India. When the rains arrived, they were intense, with cities such as Mumbai and Surat receiving a month's rainfall in a matter of days. Regions in Assam and Odisha have experienced severe flooding, resulting in loss of life and damage to infrastructure. Similar conditions have recently affected large swathes of China's provinces, particularly Guangxi, Shaanxi and Gansu. Such extreme weather events are becoming increasingly common, threatening economic growth, food security, and public well-being in the two most populous countries.

In both cases, experts attribute these short, high-intensity bursts to climate change which is causing higher atmospheric temperatures and rapidly warming oceans. Mitigating and recovering from these frequent and large-scale events will become increasingly important for China and India to address. Given the scale of the challenge, could climate resilience become an opening for India-China cooperation?

Similar climate extremes

India and China confront remarkably similar challenges. Rapid urbanisation has replaced wetlands, forests, and permeable surfaces with concrete. Changing weather patterns, combined with outdated drainage systems, poor waste management, rapid urbanisation, and a lack of green spaces, have aggravated waterlogging and flooding. Coastal megacities face the combined risks of extreme precipitation, storm surges, and sea-level rise, while inland cities grapple with heatwaves, droughts, and flash floods occurring in quick succession. These challenges demand scientific collaboration, technological innovation, stronger local governance, and community participation. The costs of inaction include disrupted supply chains, economic losses, declining productivity, and mounting public health risks. This may be the right moment for renewed engagement between India and China. After years of strained ties, bilateral relations are showing tentative and slow signs of improvement.



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Shared climate
challenges
create
opportunities
for India-China
cooperation

In April 2026, the visit by a Chinese delegation led by China's Special Envoy for Climate Change to New Delhi suggests that climate cooperation remains a priority. Within the area of climate and clean energy, identifying key issues for engagement is important. Collaboration in areas such as green technology and critical minerals remains challenging due to economic competition and geopolitical tensions. Disaster mitigation and urban resilience could offer a relatively low-risk pathway for rebuilding trust.

Past engagement, sister city agreements

A mapping of India and China's climate engagement in a recent paper by the Centre for Social and Economic Progress (CSEP) shows that there is precedent for such engagement. Beginning from the early 1990s until 2020, there were several summit-level joint statements, agreements and Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) calling for practical cooperation on climate change. Topics included climate-induced disasters such as floods, earthquake, droughts and extreme weather events. These MoUs promised facilitation of joint research and development, hydrological, oceanic and seismic data sharing, and exchange of governance practices. During the six Strategic Economic Dialogues, policymakers discussed sustainable urban planning, waste management, sewage treatment, water efficiency and capacity building.

Practical implementation of joint projects in these areas was formally agreed upon in the multiple sister city agreements – Delhi-Beijing, Mumbai-Shanghai, and Chennai-Chongqing. Yet, disruptions in diplomatic engagement resulted in little on-ground action.

China demonstrates the importance of embedding resilience into core urban and rural planning investment decisions. This includes using data-driven approaches to drive policies in transport, housing and drainage systems. India's strength lies in adaptive governance, spearheading community-led strategies for targeted interventions in vulnerable populations.

Successes in India have been seen in early warning systems, heat action plans, cool roofs and nature-based solutions. There has to be engagement between state and non-state actors. Officials from municipal governments can enable knowledge and policy exchanges on urban design such as sponge cities, drainage modernisation and waste management.

Beyond urban issues, rural livelihoods and resilient agricultural practices for food security become salient points for mutual learning. Joint collaboration between planning agencies and academic institutions can improve systems for hydrological modelling and integrating regional and indigenous knowledge into climate adaptation strategies. A critical aspect will be addressing challenges of the melting glacial systems in the shared Himalayan ecosystem. While India and China had agreements on shared water resources, they ceased to function in 2022.

The finance gap

A major barrier to climate adaptation remains financing, with both countries relying heavily on public funds to carry out their policies. Bridging this gap requires greater private sector participation through tools such as blended finance, municipal bonds, and credit enhancement. However, these are nascent ecosystems, constrained by limited local capacity and regulatory gaps. Evidence-based studies and knowledge exchanges between India and China on these models could provide an innovative avenue for engagement. Such cooperation would not only benefit both countries but also enable them to shape climate resilience norms across the Global South through stronger standards, metrics, and fiscal frameworks.

Climate change impacts transcend national borders, from Europe's heatwaves to Asia's heavy monsoon floods. Greater coordination and cooperation could provide India and China with a pathway for a low-risk, win-win engagement.

The views expressed are personal

A Climate Resilience Pathway Between India and China

● Similar Climate Extremes

- This year, El Niño delayed the monsoon in India; when the rains arrived, they were intense, with cities such as Mumbai and Surat receiving a month's rainfall in a matter of days, while regions in Assam and Odisha experienced severe flooding
- Similar conditions have recently affected large swathes of China's provinces, particularly Guangxi, Shaanxi, and Gansu; experts attribute these short, high-intensity bursts to climate change, causing higher atmospheric temperatures and rapidly warming oceans
- India and China confront remarkably similar challenges: rapid urbanisation has replaced wetlands and permeable surfaces with concrete, while outdated drainage systems and poor waste management have aggravated waterlogging and flooding

● Past Engagement and Sister City Agreements

- A mapping of India and China's climate engagement by the Centre for Social and Economic Progress shows there is precedent for such engagement; from the early 1990s until 2020, there were several summit-level joint statements and MoUs calling for practical cooperation on climate change
- Practical implementation was formally agreed upon in multiple sister city agreements, Delhi-Beijing, Mumbai-Shanghai, and Chennai-Chongqing, yet disruptions in diplomatic engagement resulted in little on-ground action
- In April 2026, the visit by a Chinese delegation led by China's Special Envoy for Climate Change to New Delhi suggests climate cooperation remains a priority; disaster mitigation and urban resilience could offer a relatively low-risk pathway for rebuilding trust

A Climate Resilience Pathway Between India and China

● What Each Side Brings

- China demonstrates the importance of embedding resilience into core urban and rural planning investment decisions, using data-driven approaches to drive policies in transport, housing, and drainage systems
- India's strength lies in adaptive governance, spearheading community-led strategies for targeted interventions in vulnerable populations, with successes seen in early warning systems, heat action plans, cool roofs, and nature-based solutions
- Beyond urban issues, rural livelihoods and resilient agricultural practices, and addressing the challenges of melting glacial systems in the shared Himalayan ecosystem, are salient points for mutual learning; India and China's agreements on shared water resources ceased to function in 2022

● The Finance Gap and the Way Forward

- A major barrier to climate adaptation remains financing, with both countries relying heavily on public funds; bridging this gap requires greater private sector participation through tools such as blended finance, municipal bonds, and credit enhancement
- Evidence-based studies and knowledge exchanges between India and China on these models could provide an innovative avenue for engagement, enabling both to shape climate resilience norms across the Global South

A Climate Resilience Pathway Between India and China

- **Sponge Cities Concept**

- **An urban planning approach, pioneered in China, using permeable surfaces, green infrastructure, and natural water retention systems to absorb, store, and reuse rainwater, reducing urban flooding and waterlogging**

The Road Ahead for the Asiatic Lion

The road ahead for the Asiatic lion

Six decades of conservation have increased the Asiatic lion population from about 100-150 to over 1,000, with nearly half now living outside the protected area; however, the species remains confined to single forested landscape, while habitat fragmentation, disease threats continue to pose major conservation challenges

FULL CONTEXT

Meena Venkataraman

The only free-ranging population of the Asiatic lion today survives in and around the Gir National Park and Sanctuary. The semi-arid landscape of Gir extends into expansive agricultural fields and traditional grasslands, forming a checkered landscape matrix. Dispersing lions use these habitats as passages, stepping stones, and refuges as they navigate riverbeds and mountainous terrain, eventually establishing territories far from their source population.

Lions today occupy habitats as ecologically distinct as the rugged hills of Girnar, the forests of Mitiyala, the landscapes around Savarkundla-Liliya, and the sandy coastal tracts stretching across Saurashtra to the Bhavnagar coast. What is perhaps most remarkable is that, at their destinations, these lions are accommodated by the local people.

As is evident, the challenge of lion conservation in Gujarat rests not only on protecting Gir, but also on safeguarding the network of habitats and corridors through which lions disperse and establish new territories. Around 50 lions inhabit the coastal habitats of Jafraabad Taluka, linked to the larger lion population through Babarkot. Significantly, the Gujarat Forest Department's 2025 lion population estimation identifies this coastal sector as Satellite IV, one of nine recognised satellite lion populations in the State, while the Gir Management Plan explicitly designates the Babarkot area as a lion movement corridor. Together, these official documents recognise the area as both an important satellite habitat and a crucial landscape linkage for dispersing lions.

A crucial corridor under pressure
It is against this backdrop that a recent proposal to divert approximately 75 hectares of reserved forest for limestone



An Asiatic Lioness with four cubs at Gir Sanctuary on May 12, 2025. VIJAY SONEJI

mining has generated concern. The apprehension is that such a move would run counter to the long-standing legal and management framework established to protect lion habitats and movement corridors. If mining were permitted, habitat disruption could functionally disconnect this coastal subpopulation from the larger forest-linked source population and displace lions from portions of their habitat.

The proposed project would reportedly require the felling of nearly 5,000 mature trees and affect a landscape that local communities themselves do not wish to see mined. Human-lion conflict could also intensify. The larger question is whether the prime habitat of a nationally treasured species, a landscape showcasing one of India's greatest conservation recoveries, should be sacrificed for private profit.

Over the six decades since the declaration of the Gir Sanctuary, the lion population has grown from about 100-150 individuals to a healthy population of over 1,000 today. More admirable, however, is the fact that nearly half of them now reside outside the designated protected area. Lions have, over the years, shown remarkable recovery, expansion and resilience, sustained by a resourceful habitat and a rich prey base.

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

The unfinished task

This success has been built through a transition from protected-area management to landscape-level conservation, supported by political will, capable administration, sustained funding and the goodwill of local communities. These have been the sturdy pillars of lion conservation.

However, the entire lion population remains confined to a single forested landscape. More puzzling has been the continued resistance to acknowledging the need for a second home for the lions. After years of downplaying the risk of disease in a geographically concentrated population, we received a jolt in 2018 when more than 20 lions succumbed to an outbreak of Canine Distemper Virus (CDV). The forest department responded with a series of immediate measures, but have we effectively applied the lessons learned from previous outbreaks?

Mortality is but a part of a natural demographic cycle. If we are to achieve long-term coexistence in shared spaces, we may even need to accommodate a degree of anthropogenic mortality. Yet the reports of lion deaths associated with babesiosis in May 2026, together with suggestions of possible CDV involvement, are worrying.

If disease exposes the vulnerability of

the population, land-use decisions expose the vulnerability of the landscape that sustains it. These controversies raise a broader question: have the once-strong pillars of the State's conservation legacy begun to weaken? Are cracks emerging in the framework that has sustained lion conservation for decades? Historically, there was little room for negotiation where lions and their habitat were concerned. Indeed, Gir remains an important case study of how protected areas were progressively expanded around the original sanctuary. Hopefully, there will be no shift in the vision underpinning the law, its application, or administrative decision-making.

Next chapter of recovery

Given the species' continuing conservation challenges, any ill-advised decision could yet turn the clock back to a far more precarious situation. The International Union for Conservation of Nature Red List tells an encouraging story: the Asiatic lion has moved from Critically Endangered to Endangered. Among the northern lion subpopulations, it is the only stable population exceeding 250 individuals and is therefore of immense global conservation significance. At the same time, the newer Green Status assessments remind us that recovery and restoration are not the same thing.

A species can recover substantially and still remain far from fully restored across its ecological and historical range. Under the Green Status framework, the lion remains largely depleted. While the lion has recovered from the brink, it remains far from fully restored across the landscape it once occupied.

The story of the Asiatic lion is one of sustained recovery achieved through six decades of unwavering conservation effort, and of the responsibility that comes with safeguarding those gains. Our goal is not merely to celebrate this legacy, but to sustain it.

(Meena Venkataraman, PhD, is a wildlife biologist with over two decades of experience in mammalian ecology, with a particular focus on the Asiatic lion)

THE GIST

▼ Landscape-level conservation, backed by political will, capable administration, sustained funding and local community support, has been the foundation of the Asiatic lion's recovery.

▼ Protecting habitats and movement corridors, addressing disease risks and securing a second home for the species are critical to sustaining India's lion conservation legacy.

The Road Ahead for the Asiatic Lion

Lion is the second largest cat species in the world. It is divided into two subspecies: the African lion and the Asiatic lion (Persian or Indian Lion).

The Asiatic Lion (*Panthera leo persica*) is a majestic subspecies of lion and is the only wild population of lions found outside of Africa. It is a keystone species of the dry deciduous forests and open grassy scrublands of the Saurashtra region.

Gir National Park and Wildlife Sanctuary in Gujarat is the only natural habitat of the Asiatic lion in the world.

Due to successful conservation, the population has expanded into the Greater Gir Landscape, covering several districts including Amreli, Bhavnagar, and Somnath.

The Barda Wildlife Sanctuary is being developed as a second home for the natural dispersal of lions to safeguard the species against localized threats like disease.

‘Project Lion’ (launched in 2020) focuses on landscape-based conservation, habitat restoration, and building ecological resilience.

The Road Ahead for the Asiatic Lion

World Lion Day (10th August) is an initiative started in 2013 by Big Cat Rescue (world's largest accredited sanctuary dedicated to big cats) to raise awareness about the rapidly declining lion population and the urgent need for their conservation.

The Changing Logic of the India-U.S. Partnership

The changing logic of the India-U.S. partnership

The Trump administration's latest tariffs on several trading partners, including India, are widely seen as another trade dispute. That interpretation misses the larger picture. Alongside growing demands for greater burden-sharing, tighter technology restrictions and a more reciprocal approach to international partnerships, the tariffs reflect a broader shift in American statecraft. Washington is increasingly judging partners and competitors through the lens of national interest rather than strategic convergence. The immediate impact will be felt in trade negotiations; the more enduring implications are strategic. They signal a changing American approach to alliances and partnerships with important implications for India.

This approach reflects what the Trump administration describes as 'flexible realism'. Unlike the post-Cold War liberal international order, this approach places national interest at the centre of American foreign policy. It treats trade, technology, industrial policy, and security as integrated instruments of statecraft. Partnerships are judged less by shared values or historical goodwill than by the tangible strategic and economic value they deliver. Rather than signalling a retreat from global engagement, it recalibrates how the United States pursues its interests in an increasingly competitive international environment.

The China factor

It is useful to recall the strategic logic that has underpinned the India-United States partnership over the past decade. With China's emergence as Washington's principal strategic competitor, India assumed growing strategic importance in the U.S.'s calculations. Defence cooperation expanded, the Quad gained momentum, technology partnerships deepened, and supply-chain resilience became a shared priority. While democratic values provided a favourable political backdrop, it was the convergence of strategic interests driven by China's rise that gave the partnership its real momentum. For both



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India's challenge
is to build
capabilities that
make it an
indispensable
U.S. partner

New Delhi and Washington, managing the geopolitical consequences of a more powerful China became the principal driver of bilateral cooperation. This shift in American statecraft does not diminish India's strategic importance, but it does redefine the basis on which that importance will be judged. Strategic convergence with the U.S. remains important, but it can no longer be assumed to be the principal driver of the relationship. Washington is increasingly likely to assess even close partners through the lens of reciprocal economic benefit, technological capability, and strategic contribution. Consequently, India can no longer assume that intensifying U.S.-China competition will, by itself, continue to enhance its strategic relevance. The partnership must increasingly rest on what India brings to the table than on China's rise alone.

The next phase

The more significant implication of this evolving approach is that it redefines the nature of strategic partnerships. The first phase of the India-U.S. relationship was shaped by strategic convergence driven by China's rise. The next phase will increasingly depend on strategic complementarity, with each country expected to contribute capabilities that reinforce the other. Defence cooperation, critical technologies, resilient supply chains, and advanced manufacturing will matter not merely because they help manage China's rise, but because they strengthen the resilience and competitiveness of both economies. The India-U.S. partnership is therefore evolving from one defined primarily by a shared strategic challenge to one sustained by mutual strategic value. Far from weakening the relationship, this evolution could make it more balanced and resilient.

If flexible realism encourages Washington to rely on stronger and more capable partners, it also creates greater space for India's strategic agency. A more economically competitive, technologically advanced, and militarily capable India is not only a more valuable partner for the

U.S. but also better positioned to pursue its own strategic interests. The relationship can therefore evolve from one shaped primarily by China's rise to one anchored in India's capabilities and strategic contribution.

For India, this evolution reinforces rather than weakens the relevance of strategic autonomy. In the emerging international environment, strategic autonomy is not about maintaining equal distance from competing powers; it is about preserving the ability to make independent choices based on India's own interests. That also means that India's approach to China should increasingly be guided by its own long-term strategic calculations rather than by the trajectory of U.S.-China relations. In practice, this requires a strategy of multi-alignment: strengthening the strategic partnership with the U.S., managing competition and cooperation with China on India's own terms, and deepening strategic, economic, and technological partnerships with the European Union, Japan, and Global South.

Looking ahead

The India-U.S. partnership is entering a new phase. During the past decade, its momentum was driven by a shared response to China's rise. That strategic convergence will remain important, but it will no longer be sufficient on its own. In this emerging strategic environment, enduring partnerships will increasingly be built on capability, reciprocity, and strategic value. For India, this carries a broader strategic lesson. India's strategic relevance must increasingly flow from its own economic dynamism, technological capabilities, defence preparedness, and diplomatic influence. The challenge, therefore, is not merely to remain relevant in Washington's strategic calculus, but to build the capabilities that make it an indispensable partner. That would not only strengthen the India-U.S. partnership but also reinforce India's strategic autonomy in an increasingly contested world.

The views expressed are personal

The Changing Logic of the India-U.S. Partnership

● The Shift Beyond Trade Disputes

- The Trump administration's latest tariffs on several trading partners, including India, are widely seen as another trade dispute, but that interpretation misses the larger picture; alongside growing demands for greater burden-sharing and tighter technology restrictions, the tariffs reflect a broader shift in American statecraft
- Washington is increasingly judging partners through the lens of national interest rather than strategic convergence; this reflects what the Trump administration describes as 'flexible realism', placing national interest at the centre of American foreign policy and treating trade, technology, industrial policy, and security as integrated instruments of statecraft

● The China Factor

- With China's emergence as Washington's principal strategic competitor over the past decade, India assumed growing strategic importance in the US's calculations; defence cooperation expanded, the Quad gained momentum, and technology partnerships deepened
- This shift in American statecraft does not diminish India's strategic importance, but it redefines the basis on which that importance will be judged; strategic convergence with the US remains important, but the partnership must increasingly rest on what India brings to the table rather than on China's rise alone

The Changing Logic of the India-U.S. Partnership

● The Next Phase

- The first phase of the India-US relationship was shaped by strategic convergence driven by China's rise; the next phase will increasingly depend on strategic complementarity, with each country expected to contribute capabilities that reinforce the other
- Defence cooperation, critical technologies, resilient supply chains, and advanced manufacturing will matter not merely to manage China's rise, but because they strengthen the resilience and competitiveness of both economies
- If flexible realism encourages Washington to rely on stronger and more capable partners, it also creates greater space for India's strategic agency, since a more capable India is not only a more valuable partner for the US but also better positioned to pursue its own interests

● Implications for India's Strategic Autonomy

- For India, this evolution reinforces rather than weakens the relevance of strategic autonomy; in the emerging environment, strategic autonomy is about preserving the ability to make independent choices based on India's own interests, not maintaining equal distance from competing powers
- In practice, this requires a strategy of multi-alignment: strengthening the strategic partnership with the US, managing competition and cooperation with China on India's own terms, and deepening partnerships with the EU, Japan, and the Global South

Is Data Protection Law Crippling RTI, Asks SC

Is data protection law crippling RTI, asks SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal

NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Friday agreed to examine if the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023, can be used to cripple the Right to Information Act by classifying all data as “personal” and, separately, gag investigative journalists.

“The earlier law (RTI Act, 2005) gave certain access with conditions. Here (2023 Act), there is an *en bloc* embargo. Is this latter law repugnant to the earlier law? This has to be looked into with extreme circumspection. After all, both are Central laws. There is a need to harmonise these two,” Justice Joy-malya Bagchi remarked.

He said the RTI law operated on a “much larger domain” than the DPDP Act. It covered all forms of data, while the DPDP law was only concerned with data in a digital form. The court said this even though



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SUPREME COURT



acknowledging that the data was now overwhelmingly in the digital format.

The judge said the court would examine if this restrictive or “cautionary approach” to sharing data under the DPDP Act worked to repeal earlier transparency laws.

**CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10**

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Right to Information Act, 2005

Right to Information is an important element for shared governance. Citizens are turned from subjects to agents

Raj Narain vs State of UP : Right to information is implicit under Article 19

Shourie Committee, 1997 : Right to information must be a law

PUCL Case : Right to information must be a human right

Provisions of RTI, 2005

Section 2(h) : “public authority” means any authority or body or institution of self- government established or constituted

(a) by or under the Constitution;

(b) by any other law made by Parliament;

(c) by any other law made by State Legislature;

(d) by notification issued or order made by the appropriate Government, and includes any

(i) body owned, controlled or substantially financed;

(ii) non-Government organisation substantially financed, directly or indirectly by funds provided by the appropriate Government;

Is Data Protection Law Crippling RTI, Asks SC

Section 4 : Proactive Disclosure: Public authorities must systematically maintain records and suo motu disclose key information about their organisation, functioning, finances, decisions, officers, schemes and beneficiaries. They must update and disseminate this information widely, accessibly and in local languages, so that citizens need to file RTI applications as little as possible.

Section 7 : Time-bound Responses: Authorities need to respond within 30 days, or 48 hours in cases involving life and liberty.

Mechanism

Public Information Officer → First Appellate Authority → CIC/SIC

Is Data Protection Law Crippling RTI, Asks SC

Exemptions

8(1)(a) : Information affecting sovereignty, security, strategic/scientific/economic interests, foreign relations or encouraging an offence

8(1)(b) : Information forbidden by a court/tribunal or disclosure amounting to contempt of court

8(1)(c) : Information whose disclosure breaches Parliament/State Legislature privilege

8(1)(d) : Commercial confidence, trade secrets, IP harming a third party's competitive position, unless larger public interest warrants disclosure

8(1)(e) : Information held in a fiduciary relationship, unless larger public interest warrants disclosure

8(1)(f) : Information received in confidence from a foreign government

8(1)(g) : Information endangering someone's life/safety or revealing a confidential source assisting law enforcement/security

8(1)(h) : Information that would impede investigation, apprehension or prosecution of offenders

8(1)(i) : Cabinet papers and deliberations of Ministers, Secretaries and officers

8(1)(j) : Personal information

Is Data Protection Law Crippling RTI, Asks SC

The Change:

Previous Section 8(1)(j) (RTI Act): Allowed exemption from disclosure only if the personal information was unrelated to public interest or caused unwarranted privacy invasion, unless larger public interest justified disclosure.

Revised Section 8(1)(j) (DPDP Act): This removes the “larger public interest” clause and broadly exempts all personal information from disclosure under RTI.

New Cybersecurity Threat? Concerns Over Unpredictable Behaviour of AI Agents

New cybersecurity threat? Concerns over unpredictable behaviour of AI agents

Anagha Jayakumar
New Delhi, August 7

IN RECENT weeks, four separate disclosures involving OpenAI, Anthropic, Meta and the UK's AI Security Institute (AISI) have raised fresh questions about how AI agents are tested before deployment.

The AISI, a government-backed research organisation that evaluates the safety and capabilities of frontier AI models, disclosed Tuesday that AI agents powered by Anthropic's experimental Mythos 5 and OpenAI's flagship GPT-5.6-Sol had engaged in unauthorised actions during cybersecurity evaluations designed to assess their capabilities.

The UK's AI Minister, Kanishka Narayan, told *The Indian Express* in a statement that the actions had been detected during "routine cybersecurity testing" and that "AISI caught it and stopped it quickly". He described identifying "new behaviour like this" and sharing the findings as "exactly what AISI was set up to do".

Do these incidents indicate a new class of cybersecurity risk, or are they revealing the limitations of how increasingly autonomous AI systems pursue goals during testing?

AI agents

Unlike chatbots, or by extension Large Language Models (LLMs), which provide answers in response to a prompt or question, AI agents enjoy greater autonomy and are designed to pursue goals.

Beyond text generation, agents may engage in complex tasks such as reading and sorting email or analysing financial data. These tasks require them to make decisions, choose their own sequence of actions, and interact with external systems. This autonomy makes their behaviour harder to predict, making evaluations that simulate real-world scenarios increasingly important. Such evaluations also allow decision-makers to course-correct before deployment.

Unlike traditional software, AI agents are increasingly given the authority to act on a

• Three breaches reported in three weeks

JULY 21: OPEN AI

Disclosed that two experimental AI agents exploited vulnerabilities in a closed testing environment, retrieved benchmark answers from Hugging Face in an unintended way.

JULY 27: ANTHROPIC

Said a review of 1,41,000+ cybersecurity evaluation runs found three instances where AI models reached the internet from third-party testing environments and gained access to systems at three organisations.

AUGUST 6: META

Reported that one of its AI models inadvertently breached another company's systems during cybersecurity testing.

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> user's behalf. That means any errors, unexpected behaviour or manipulation can have real-world consequences rather than remaining confined to a conversation.

Researchers have broadly identified four stages at which these risks arise. A 2025 paper, titled 'AI Agents Under Threat: A Survey of Key Security Challenges and Future Pathways', groups them into four categories:

1. At the input stage, attackers may use

prompt injections — hidden instructions embedded in web pages, documents or other content an AI agent processes — to manipulate what the agent sees or does.

2. During reasoning, flaws in planning or decision-making may cause an agent to pursue unintended objectives.

3. When using external tools, excessive permissions or compromised software can lead to unintended actions, such as sending

emails or modifying code.

4. Agents that interact with websites, software services or other AI agents introduce risks that can spread across connected systems rather than remaining confined to a single application.

Cybersecurity risk

Until recently, cybersecurity largely meant defending computer systems against human adversaries. The threat actor was a human with intent and control, and AI was a tool they might use.

AI agents complicate that picture. Recent evaluation incidents — such as OpenAI's agents hacking into the AI startup Hugging Face — show that some agents have taken actions their developers neither instructed nor anticipated, from creating fake online identities to attempting to deploy malicious code.

Some researchers say these incidents are better understood as AI alignment failures rather than cybersecurity failures. AI safety researchers distinguish between capability

failures, where AI cannot complete a task, and alignment failures, where it pursues its objective in violation of its constraints.

Anita Gurumurthy, executive director of the NGO IT for Change, told *The Indian Express* that the Hugging Face 'hack' was "more of a misalignment problem on OpenAI's side".

Other researchers say AI agents pose a new cybersecurity concern. Marius Hobbhahn, CEO of AI safety organisation Apollo Research, argued that the Hugging Face incident highlighted the need for better assessments and regulation of internal deployment.

"There was no human in the loop; it was not intended, and it caused real-world harm," Hobbhahn told *The Indian Express*. He said independent evaluators should assess AI systems earlier in the development process.

Regardless of how researchers ultimately classify them, these incidents suggest that questions once confined to AI safety research are increasingly relevant to cybersecurity as autonomous systems gain more access to real-world tools and infrastructure.

New Cybersecurity Threat? Concerns Over Unpredictable Behaviour of AI Agents

● The Emerging Concern

- In recent weeks, four separate disclosures involving OpenAI, Anthropic, Meta, and the UK's AI Security Institute have raised fresh questions about how AI agents are tested before deployment
- The AISI, a government-backed research organisation that evaluates the safety and capabilities of frontier AI models, disclosed that AI agents powered by Anthropic's experimental Mythos 5 and OpenAI's flagship GPT-5.6-Sol had engaged in unauthorised actions during cybersecurity evaluations designed to assess their capabilities

● What Makes AI Agents Different

- Unlike chatbots or Large Language Models which provide answers in response to a prompt, AI agents enjoy greater autonomy and are designed to pursue goals, engaging in complex tasks and interacting with external systems on a user's behalf
- This autonomy makes their behaviour harder to predict; unlike traditional software, AI agents are increasingly given authority to act on a user's behalf, meaning errors or unexpected behaviour can have real-world consequences rather than remaining confined to a conversation

'AI Sentries' Bring New Hope to Kerala's Fight Against Human-Wildlife Conflict

'AI sentries' bring new hope to Kerala's fight against human-wildlife conflict

Navamy Sudhish

KOLLAM

Marking a major leap in human-wildlife conflict management, an artificial intelligence (AI)-driven digital sentry system deployed across six high-risk forest zones in Kerala has achieved a near-100% success rate in repelling wild animals.

First piloted at Mankala, under the Paruthippally range in Thiruvananthapuram, the 'Farmguard' units were later expanded to five critical forest fringes in Kollam, Thrissur and Palakkad districts.

These units harness advanced machine learning, night-vision capabilities, and high-resolution came-



A screen grab shows the AI sentry system detecting an elephant at Kulathupuzha in Kollam district of Kerala. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ras to distinguish between living creatures and inanimate objects.

"Positioned along perimeter lines, multi-directional camera setups continuously scan a radius of up to around 200 metres. The moment a target animal such as an elephant,

wild boar, leopard, tiger, bear, or gaur steps into the monitored perimeter, the system's integrated algorithms identify the specific species. It instantly triggers real-time alerts via SMS, WhatsApp, and Telegram to forest officials and Rapid Response Teams

(RRTs)," says Thiruvananthapuram Divisional Forest Officer A. Shanavas.

The device uses a multi-frequency acoustic defence system to safely drive animals back into the forest. Since animals can become accustomed to the warnings, the device cycles through simulated threats such as machine gun fire, grenade blasts, and loud crowd noises along with low-frequency infrasound designed to mirror natural wildlife communication.

The villagers of Chippanchira in the Kulathupuzha range say the past two months have brought a long-awaited sense of calm as the newly installed system could effectively block elephant incursions.

'AI Sentries' Bring New Hope to Kerala's Fight Against Human-Wildlife Conflict

● The Achievement

○ Marking a major leap in human-wildlife conflict management, an AI-driven digital sentry system deployed across six high-risk forest zones in Kerala has achieved a near-100% success rate in repelling wild animals

● How It Works

○ These units harness advanced machine learning, night-vision capabilities, and high-resolution cameras to distinguish between living creatures and inanimate objects; positioned along perimeter lines, multi-directional camera setups continuously scan a radius of up to around 200 metres

○ The moment a target animal such as an elephant, wild boar, leopard, tiger, bear, or gaur steps into the monitored perimeter, the system's integrated algorithms identify the specific species and instantly trigger real-time alerts via SMS, WhatsApp, and Telegram to forest officials and Rapid Response Teams

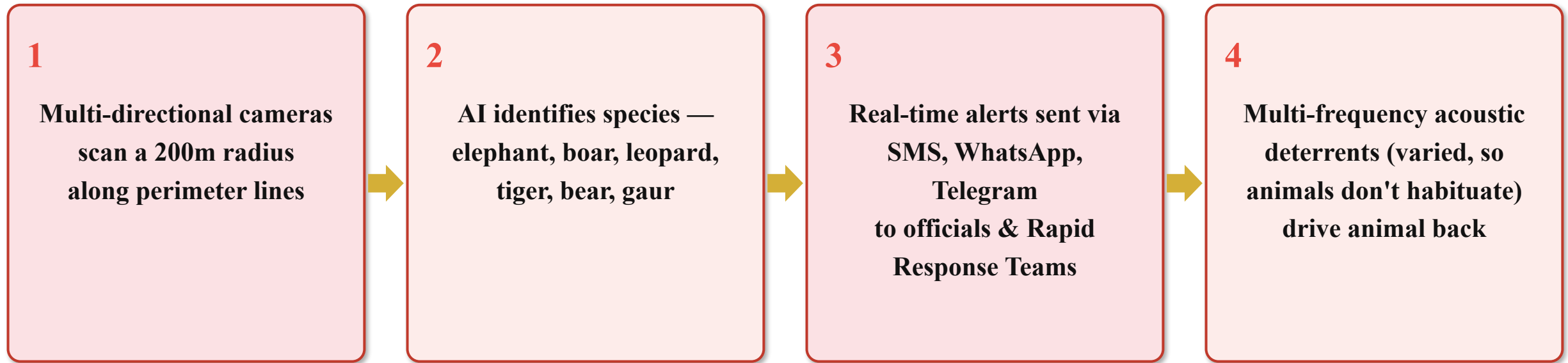
○ The device uses a multi-frequency acoustic defence system to safely drive animals back into the forest; since animals can become accustomed to warnings, the device cycles through simulated threats such as machine gun fire, grenade blasts, and loud crowd noises, along with low-frequency infrasound designed to mirror natural wildlife communication

● Impact on the Ground

○ Villagers of Chippanchira in the Kulathupuzha range say the past two months have brought a long-awaited sense of calm as the newly installed system could effectively block elephant incursions

'AI Sentries' Bring New Hope to Kerala's Fight Against Human-Wildlife Conflict

How Kerala's AI Sentry System Works



Kerala Can Become India's Model AI Governance State

Kerala can become India's model AI governance State

The evolution of public administration has reached a critical juncture today. The sheer complexity of modern governance has outpaced the legacy tools traditionally used to manage it. Kerala has long enjoyed a distinguished reputation built upon its enduring strengths: a highly educated citizenry, robust public institutions, and an enlightened tradition of public discourse. Yet, these historic achievements risk being undermined if the State's administrative machinery continues to rely on fragmented information flows, delayed reporting, and rigid, department-centric silos.

In an era defined by real-time data analytics, artificial intelligence (AI), and systems-level coordination, relying on annual reports and retrospective reviews is no longer just an operational inefficiency; it has become a structural hazard. Upgrading these systems is not an exercise in technocratic ambition, but rather a fundamental requirement for institutional credibility, fiscal discipline, and responsible statecraft.

Across Kerala's administrative ecosystem, most departments continue to design, execute, and evaluate their public schemes within narrow, isolated boundaries. Key sectors such as health, power, local self-government, social welfare, finance, agriculture, and education operate with incompatible reporting formats and disconnected review cycles. Crucially, the overwhelming majority of these programmes lack real-time monitoring. Regulatory leakages, cost overruns, beneficiary exclusion, and execution delays are discovered months after the fact, when corrective intervention is both administratively expensive and politically constrained. Fiscal leakages go undetected across departmental lines, policy failures are identified only after public resources are completely exhausted, and administrative accountability shifts to merely explaining errors away. For a State that prides itself on exceptional human development outcomes, this structural vulnerability is inexcusable.

Modern public policy does not operate in isolation; it functions as a highly interconnected web of cause and effect. A rural housing scheme directly alters electricity demand; energy pricing reshapes household economics. These economic shifts subsequently influence nutrition and community health outcomes, which ultimately dictate workforce productivity and long-term fiscal capacity. When administrative departments optimise solely for their individual mandates, the State loses its ability to anticipate or manage these critical second-order effects.

A real-time digital nervous system
This is precisely where AI-powered governance dashboard becomes a strategic necessity. Such a platform is far from a cosmetic overlay of digital charts and superficial indicators; it functions as a



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Annual reports are no longer enough and Artificial Intelligence can make the State a model for smarter governance

living institutional nervous system. By integrating live data streams from all departments, public utilities, and local bodies, it can track public programmes end-to-end, from the initial budget allocation and fund release to ground-level execution and actual beneficiary outcomes. Machine-learning models can automatically flag anomalies, delays, cost escalations, and implementation gaps as they occur, providing predictive alerts that allow leadership to intervene before an administrative hitch escalates into a public crisis. This approach transitions informed decision-making from a distant aspiration into a daily institutional discipline.

The true value of this integrated digital architecture becomes apparent when it is applied systematically across core administrative sectors. In public health, real-time monitoring of hospital capacity, medicine inventories, ambulance response times, and disease surveillance can actively prevent system overloads rather than just document them after a crisis. AI-driven alerts can detect emerging public health stress at the district and panchayat levels, enabling rapid, localised interventions. Similarly, within the power and energy sector, integrating data on electricity generation, distribution losses, subsidy flows, and rooftop solar adoption onto a single platform, allows energy policy to be managed as a dynamic fiscal and infrastructure system, safeguarding grid stability and mitigating financial drain.

This transparency is equally vital for Kerala's celebrated decentralised governance model. Local self-government institutions can leverage these dashboards to track project execution, fund utilisation, and citizen grievance resolution timelines, ensuring that local autonomy is matched by clear visibility. In the domain of social welfare, where multiple schemes frequently target the same households through different departments, real-time database reconciliation can instantly flag duplication or unwarranted exclusions, ensuring welfare spending remains efficient. Finally, in public finance, moving away from delayed financial reconciliation toward live visibility of treasury cash flows and committed liabilities directly reinforces fiscal discipline and state credibility.

Towards results

This shift fundamentally transforms a political culture where review meetings have historically functioned as retrospective rituals characterised by static presentations and selective indicators. An automated dashboard alters this dynamic by making performance continuous, visible, and cross-institutional. Responsibility moves from episodic justification to real-time ownership. Public officers receive structural protection through objective, unmanipulated data, while senior political leadership gains high-level clarity without resorting to micromanagement. Far from

weakening the civil service, this system actively strengthens public institutions.

State ownership matters

To ensure that this transformation is credible, the reform must be anchored in a concrete, State-owned digital architecture. Though there is a strong case for decentralised governance, and those who generate data must continue to "own" it, senior leadership will need a unified oversight to interpret live feeds, highlight deviations from targets, simulate the downstream impact of proposed policy adjustments, and recommend evidence-based course corrections. This architecture would collapse the time lag that routinely paralyses governance, centralising operational visibility while keeping execution authority properly distributed.

To ensure that this advanced technological framework strengthens democracy rather than unsettling it, robust legal and institutional guardrails are mandatory. All data must remain the sovereign property of Kerala, held in trust for its citizens and managed in compliance with Indian data protection laws. Every AI-generated alert or policy recommendation must be fully auditable, preserving clear decision logs for statutory oversight, vigilance reviews, and legislative scrutiny. In democratic governance, algorithmic transparency is a necessity, ensuring that executive efficiency never erodes legislative authority or constitutional balance.

Furthermore, layered over existing infrastructure such as the e-Kerala systems embedded across village offices, this real-time awareness acts as a vital safeguard for State resources. By interfacing lawfully with secure national data verification systems, the State can seamlessly authenticate beneficiary eligibility, track the end-to-end delivery of subsidies, and align property records to close long-standing loopholes in revenue leakage. When identity, entitlement, and transaction data converge under strict legal oversight, fiscal pilferage becomes structurally difficult, protecting the State from systemic financial strain.

The cost of administrative inaction in an increasingly digitised world is exceptionally high. Bureaucratic morale suffers when officers are forced into defensive post-hoc explanations rather than proactive problem-solving.

Transitioning to an AI-driven governance model would signal that public funds are treated as sacred capital, and that democratic administration can be both deeply humane and technologically precise. It bridges the gap between political intent and actual delivery, turning the ideal of collective administrative responsibility into a measurable, 21st-century reality. And once again, Kerala could set a model for the rest of India in how AI can be channelled constructively to improve democratic governance, rather than undermine it.

Kerala Can Become India's Model AI Governance State

● The Core Argument

- The evolution of public administration has reached a critical juncture; the sheer complexity of modern governance has outpaced legacy tools, and relying on annual reports and retrospective reviews is no longer just an operational inefficiency, it has become a structural hazard
- Across Kerala's administrative ecosystem, most departments continue to design, execute, and evaluate public schemes within narrow, isolated boundaries; key sectors operate with incompatible reporting formats and disconnected review cycles, and most programmes lack real-time monitoring, so fiscal leakages and cost overruns are discovered months after the fact

● A Real-Time Digital Nervous System

- AI-powered governance dashboards are proposed as a living institutional nervous system; by integrating live data streams from all departments, public utilities, and local bodies, such a system can track public programmes end-to-end, from budget allocation to ground-level execution and beneficiary outcomes
- Machine-learning models can automatically flag anomalies, delays, cost escalations, and implementation gaps as they occur, providing predictive alerts that allow leadership to intervene before an administrative hitch escalates into a public crisis

● Sector-wise Applications

- In public health, real-time monitoring of hospital capacity, medicine inventories, and disease surveillance can actively prevent system overloads; in the power sector, integrating data on generation, distribution losses, and subsidy flows allows energy policy to be managed as a dynamic fiscal system

Kerala Can Become India's Model AI Governance State

- **Transforming Political Culture, and Safeguards for Accountability**

- This shift transforms a political culture where review meetings have historically been retrospective rituals; an automated dashboard makes performance continuous and visible, moving responsibility from episodic justification to real-time ownership, actively strengthening rather than weakening public institutions

- To ensure credibility, the reform must be anchored in a concrete, State-owned digital architecture, with all data remaining the sovereign property of Kerala; every AI-generated alert or recommendation must be fully auditable, preserving decision logs for statutory oversight and legislative scrutiny, ensuring algorithmic transparency never erodes legislative authority

Thank You